

Name: _____

Date: _____

The Label on My Coat

Year 6 reading comprehension · Story · 15 marks · About 30 minutes

It was the first of September 1939, and war was coming. The platform at the station was a sea of coats, cases and brown luggage labels. Dorothy kept a tight hold on her brother's hand. Peter was only six, and his gas mask box bumped against his knees with every step. Somewhere a guard's whistle shrilled, and a mother turned away so that her child would not see her face.

"Don't cry," she told him, though her own throat felt tight. "It's an adventure. We'll be home by Christmas."

She had no way of knowing whether this was true. Mum had said it at the gate, smiling a smile that did not reach her eyes.

Pinned to Dorothy's coat was a label in her mother's neat writing: Dorothy Ashby, aged eleven. Peter Ashby, aged six. She touched it with one finger. It seemed strange to be turned into a parcel, to be sent away with her name on a piece of card in case she was lost.

The train rattled through the countryside for hours. London's smoke and chimneys gave way to hedgerows and fields, so green that they hurt her eyes. Peter fell asleep against her shoulder. Dorothy stayed awake, watching the unfamiliar world slide by.

At the village hall, which smelled of floor polish and damp wool, a stern woman in a green hat walked slowly down the line of children, choosing. Dorothy straightened her back. She had heard whispers that nobody wanted to take two.

Eventually, a round-faced woman in an apron stopped in front of them. "Well now," she said gently, crouching to Peter's level, "I expect you two are hungry. I've a pot of stew on the stove and a bed with two pillows. Will you come?"

Dorothy looked at her brother, and then at the woman, whose hands were rough from work but whose eyes were kind. For the first time that day, her shoulders came down from around her ears. "Yes, please," she whispered. "We would like that."

1. What was written on the label pinned to Dorothy's coat? (1 mark)

2. The story says Dorothy watched "the unfamiliar world" slide by. What does "unfamiliar" mean? (1 mark)

3. Dorothy says, “We’ll be home by Christmas”, but she “had no way of knowing” if it was true. Why do you think she said it? (2 marks)

4. Mum smiled “a smile that did not reach her eyes”. What does this suggest about how Mum was feeling? (2 marks)

5. Dorothy feels “turned into a parcel”. Explain what she means and why she feels this way. (2 marks)

6. How does Dorothy show that she is a caring older sister? Give two examples. (2 marks)

7. Describe how Dorothy’s feelings change from the start of the story to the end. Use evidence from the story. (3 marks)

8. Why do you think Dorothy “straightened her back” as the woman in the green hat walked down the line? (2 marks)

Writing task: Imagine you are Dorothy. Write a letter to your mum on your first night in the village.
